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Reducing Salesperson Turnover Intentions via Organizational Market Orientation and Selective Hiring: A Job Demand-Resources Approach

David E. Fleming[a], Andrew B. Artis[b], Eric G. Harris[c], J. Ricky Ferguson[a], and Matthew A Askew[d]

[a]Scott College of Business, Indiana State University, Terre Haute, IN, USA; [b]Muma College of Business, University of South Florida, Tampa, FL, USA; [c]Interstitial Lung Disease Specialist, Barney Barnett School of Business and Free Enterprise, Florida Southern College, Lakeland, FL, USA; [d]Boehringer Ingelheim Pharmaceuticals, Inc, Ridgefield, CT, USA

ABSTRACT

Purpose: This study is designed to respond to repeated calls for research on sales person retentionby building upon a mature research stream to identify ways to reduce turnover in boundary spanning employees and the resultant effect it has on organizational productivity. Specifically, this research draws on the Job Demands-Resources model to explore the effect of employee perceptions of firm market orientation as a way to reduce role stressors and subsequently turnover intentions. It also looks at employee traits that may serve as a buffer to the role stress to turnover intentions link and can be part of the hiring selection process (in this case grit). In so doing, this research uses a sample of early career salespeople to examine the effects of a firm's market orientation (MO) and selective hiring for specific traits (level of grit) on a salesperson's intention to quit using Job Demand-Resources as a framework.
Design/Methodology/Approach: The authors utilized a questionnaire to collect data from a sample consisting of 260 respondents who were employed full-time and worked in either B2B or B2C sales as boundary-spanning employees. The measures utilized in this study have been used in previous research and have demonstrated acceptable reliability and validity. Analysis of the latent constructs was conducted using PLS-SEM. The model was assessed as specified in the hypotheses and was estimated using the PLS algorithm to obtain path coefficient estimates.
Findings: Findings suggest that organizations can benefit internally from strong MO by mitigating stressors placed on boundary-spanning employees. Those who perceived strong MO in their employer experienced more clearly defined roles, which led to decreased role ambiguity. These increased levels of job satisfaction, which reduced turnover intention. Additionally, Grit appears to only moderate the link between role conflict and job satisfaction, which suggests that grit can serve as an additional resource salespeople can tap into in response to the demands of role stressors thereby reducing their likelihood of leaving their positions.
Research Implications: In this research, inclusion of market orientation as an antecedent to role stressors in the Job Demands-Resources model expands the conceptualization of the construct as it relates to salespeople in that market orientation is something the firm can control directly. This opens research opportunities to use this model in the sales literature. In addition, the job-demands-resources model expands the role of grit beyond positive psychology to be viewed as a resource in stressful situations and puts the role of grit into a theoretical framework for use in business contexts. As such, the current work suggests that the grit scale can be used to replace measures used for similar constructs such as tenacity.
Practical Implications: This research suggests that role ambiguity can be reduced by the presence of a market orientation. This reduction in role ambiguity leads to an increase in job satisfaction which leads to reduced turnover intention. Thus, this study indicates that there may be a cost-saving benefit (e.g. recruiting and retention efforts, lost sales, etc.) that accrues to firms with a market orientation due to reduced salesperson turnover via role perceptions. This supports that the idea that organizations can benefit from market orientation not only externally, but also internally in terms of mitigating stressors placed on boundary-spanning employees. Therefore, companies should push for adoption of market orientation in order to alleviate some key role stressors placed on their salespeople in addition to the already established benefits from external customers.

The link between grit, job satisfaction, and turnover intentions is another positive finding. As expected, job satisfaction helps reduce turnover intentions; however, the relationship is moderated by grit in such a way that people with higher grit show a weaker link between job satisfaction and turnover intentions while those with lower levels of grit show a stronger link between job satisfaction and turnover intentions. This raises human resource issues in the hiring process: human

KEYWORDS
Sales; turnover intentions; grit; market orientation; role stress; role ambiguity; employee satisfaction

CONTACT David E. Fleming david.fleming@indstate.edu Scott College of Business, Indiana State University, 30 N 7th Street, Terre Haute, IN 47809, USA

resource managers should work to identify salespeople with high levels of grit in order to better minimize turnover intentions given the cost of turnover to organizations.
Originality: This research expands existing research by examining the effects of a firm's market orientation (MO) and selective hiring for specific traits (level of grit) on a salesperson's intention to quit using Job Demand-Resources as a framework Combining these two literature streams – market orientation and salesperson grit – is novel and will inspire new thinking and foster new insights. This study serves as a starting point for future research to examine firm controllable resources (market orientation) along with employee traits that can act as a buffer (grit) when resources are scarce.

It is clear that employers are currently searching for employee retention strategies unlike at any time before (e.g., Cook 2021; Rajabi et al. 2021; Thomas 2021). As reported by the US (Bureau of Labor Statiics 2021), US based employers have seen an increase in the number of people quitting their jobs, with the number reaching 4.43 million during the period currently referred to as the "Great Resignation." Boundary spanning employees, as Zagorsky (2022) notes, have exhibited an exorbitantly high resignation rate, exceeding the average "quit rate" of 3% during this period. The issue is especially relevant in sales settings, where turnover rates have been as high as 70% annually (Katsikea, Theodosiou and Morgan 2014) and companies have frequently incurred costs upward of 200% of employees' salaries due to recruitment and training initiatives (DeConinck and Johnson 2009).

It can be argued that in today's environment dysfunctional turnover among salespeople is an even more significant problem than ever before (Thomas 2021). Exacerbating the problem is the effect of the COVID pandemic, which led even more professionals to make job changes for personal and professional reasons (Cook 2021). The climate also contributed to 2021 being the first year in the previous decade wherein employee engagement began to decline (Harter 2022). It is therefore important to consider strategies, both top-down and bottom-up that will reduce the turnover intention of salespeople especially at an early career stage. This is especially relevant given that millennial workers (and thus in the early stages of their careers) are the largest generation in the modern US workforce (Fry 2018). Accordingly, the current study is designed to respond to repeated calls for such research (e.g., Cook 2021; Rajabi et al. 2021; Thomas 2021) by building upon a mature research stream to identify ways to reduce turnover and the resultant effect it has on organizational productivity.

This research pulls from both the management (Jobs Demands/Resources Model) and positive-psychology (grit) domains while addressing these issues. By drawing from these disparate domains, an improved understanding of the antecedents and moderating conditions of salesforce turnover emerges. The JDR approach, as well as the *theory of conservation of resources* (Hobfoll 1989), provides a framework for a model which posits that the increased market orientation of a firm has positive internal consequences in terms of reduced role stressors (both conflict and ambiguity), increased job satisfaction, and reduced turnover intentions for salespeople. Furthermore, the model posits that grit (a personal resource) plays an important moderating role between role stressors, job satisfaction, and turnover intentions. While many executives emphasize the importance of being market-oriented through a sustained focus on customer, competitor, and inter-functional activities (Narver and Slater, 1990), it is necessary to examine the internal consequences of focusing on these activities as they pertain to salespeople's role stressors, job satisfaction and turnover intentions within the organization, and how grit plays a role in these relationships.

Literature review

Salesperson turnover

A review of the salesperson-turnover literature from the past three decades highlights important insights into one of the most pressing issues that sales managers face: salesperson turnover (see Appendix 1). Such a review reveals that variables previously investigated can be grouped into five categories relating to the: 1) individual, 2) job, 3) supervisor, 4) organization, and 5) environment. While insights have certainly been gained with resultant contributions to the literature, the countermeasures available to managers have been somewhat limited, and methodological concerns have been raised (DeConinck, Moss, and Deconinck 2018; Johnston et al. 1987). Notably, these limitations have been recognized for decades. Rajabi et al. (2021) have attempted to address some of these limitations with a longitudinal study of salesperson job satisfaction, organizational commitment and turnover, but even their extensive model does not examine the antecedents of role stress in a sales context.

Accordingly, finding new perspectives and approaches is critical, while recognizing changes that have occurred in salesforce composition and associated limitations of previous work. First, for practitioners, the composition of *who* is performing the selling function has changed. As of 2017, millennial workers are now the largest age-cohort within the US workforce (Fry 2018), and women currently comprise nearly 50% of professional US workers (Kochhar 2020). Second, for researchers, many extant studies either did not apply theory, or failed to report the theory that was utilized. Third, and also for researchers, problems have existed regarding the generalizability of findings given that many studies were done with salespeople in a single firm. The current study addresses these issues while including a sample of younger, diverse salespeople across multiple firms.

Theoretical foundations

As detailed previously, the current work draws from the Job-Demands/Resources approach (JD-R). A central assumption of the JD-R model is that the specific work characteristics of any job can be modeled as either job demands or job resources (Bakker, Demerouti, and Verbeke 2004). The JD-R approach suggests that employees become mentally exhausted, or experience burnout, when demands placed on their job are too great and when the resources available to complete the job are limited (Demerouti et al. 2001). Existing research (e.g., Bakker, Demerouti, and Verbeke 2004; Demerouti et al. 2001; Schaufeli 2017) has utilized the JD-R model to examine the impact of job demands and resources on burnout. In addition, extant research (e.g., Lewin and Sager 2008; Westbrook and Peterson 2020) has examined the connection between burnout and turnover intentions. The wealth of existing research connecting JD-R to burnout and then burnout to turnover clearly elucidates how the use of the JD-R framework will aid in explaining salesperson turnover.

The JD-R model is built, in part, on the theory of conservation of resources (Hobfoll 1989), which asserts that employees aim to assemble and preserve resources, and that they become threatened by the possible loss of these resources. This approach has added significantly to the employee performance literature. Work resources are conceptualized as being either personal (e.g., personality traits) or job-related (e.g., firm market orientation), and the approach suggests that when sales employees are threatened by the loss or depletion of the resources needed to complete a job, they experience mental exhaustion and stress. One way to mitigate this process is through the implementation of internal marketing (Pollen 2021), which is conceptualized by Berry (1981) as treating employees as internal customers who receive other employees' work as products that satisfy needs and wants that enable them to meet the needs of the organization.

Market orientation

A vital assumption which captures the concept of internal marketing is the idea that "to have satisfied customers, the firm must also have satisfied employees" (George 1977, 91). A fundamental tool to achieve employee satisfaction is treating employees as customers (Berry 1981; Rafiq and Ahmed 2000). One way to assist internal marketing, i.e., treating employees as customers, is to ensure an organization's proactive and clear adoption of a market orientation, conceptualized herein as a job-related resource. According to Narver and Slater (1995)), market orientation consists of three major areas – customer orientation, competitor orientation, and inter-functional orientation – and each can provide substantial benefits to salespeople. *Customer orientation* focuses on being knowledgeable enough about one's customers to continually create superior value; salespeople can help create this value for customers by enhancing their benefits in relation to costs, or by decreasing costs in relation to perceived benefits. *Competitor orientation* emphasizes understanding the facets of current competitors and potential future competitors; knowledge of competitive strengths and opportunities can assist salespeople when selling the strength of their firms' offerings against the weaknesses of competitors. *Inter-functional coordination* ensures that all company resources are deployed in a manner that creates superior value; this benefits salespeople by providing a superior value chain that is more responsive and beneficial than those of competitors. Kohli and Jaworski (1990) similarly define market orientation as the adoption of the marketing concept including generating market intelligence, disseminating it throughout the organization and organization-wide responsiveness to the information. For example, Kholi and Jaworski's study (1990) indicated that adopting a market orientation causes employees to develop a sense of pride in belonging to an organization wherein all employees work toward serving customers. In addition, Gounaris, Chryssochoidis, and Boukis (2020) also show that internal market orientation indirectly impacts team performance when it comes to new service development through climate and team integration. To truly develop a strong internal marketing presence, firms must focus on the customer orientation and inter-functional coordination aspects of the marketing orientation concept. This idea allows firms to develop an understanding of their employees and develop a responsive and unique value proposition for employees.

When employees feel more valued and have better communication with their firm via a firm's strong market orientation toward its internal customers (i.e., employees) role stressors are decreased. Studies such as Jones, Busch, and Dacin (2003) hypothesize that market orientation does in fact decrease role stressors (i.e., ambiguity and conflict), which in turn, increases job satisfaction as the direction of market orientation outlines specific salesperson goals. Recent studies have emerged to examine the role of market orientation in the industrial marketing context (e.g., Crick, Karami, and Crick 2022; Gligor et al. 2021), however, they focus on firm level return on assets and customer outcomes respectively and do not examine market orientation's role in employee outcomes such as turnover intentions or actual turnover behaviors.

Role stress

The two major role stressors, role conflict and role ambiguity, have been studied extensively since originally conceptualized by Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman (1970). Role conflict is most common when the expected roles of an employee within an organization are perceived as being inconsistent. This conflict thereby creates stress on individuals by introducing conflicting demands, a stressor that must be resolved in order to enhance employee satisfaction, and to assist an organization in reaching its goals (Biddle 1986). Similarly, role ambiguity creates stress for employees because they are unsure of what they should be doing in their job (Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970) and also unsure of how to assess if they are meeting the expectations of their position. Prior research advocates that companies who are market oriented have a clearer mission, leading to a better understanding of their direction across the organization (Kohli and Jaworski 1990; Narver and Slater 1995). This should lead to a reduction in role stressors among salespeople, due to the fact that the successful implementation of a market orientation relies upon inter-functional coordination and communication (Narver and Slater 1995). Greater coordination and communication creates less conflict and ambiguity among boundary-spanning employees in regards to their expected behaviors, their responsibilities both inside and outside the organization, and their duties in helping to implement the organization's strategic plan. This leads to the first two hypotheses:

H1a: Higher levels of market orientation perceived by the salesperson will lead to lower levels of role conflict for the salesperson.

H1b: Higher levels of market orientation perceived by the salesperson will lead to lower levels of role ambiguity for the salesperson.

Salesperson outcomes

Substantial evidence in the literature reveals that as role stress increases, job satisfaction decreases (e.g., Bedeian and Armenakis 1981; Johnson and Stinson

1975; Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970) and turnover intentions rise (e.g., Bedeian and Armenakis 1981; Bluedorn 1982; Mobley et al. 1979; Shore and Martin 1989). Support for these assertions are found in the original work of Churchill, Ford, and Walker (1976) up through the meta-analysis of Rajabi et al. (2021), all of whom found that when salespeople are unsure of what is expected of them, how to meet those expectations, or how their work will be assessed, they are more likely to be dissatisfied with their jobs. A consistent second order effect of role stressors, mediated through job dissatisfaction, found by these studies is that job satisfaction is negatively related to turnover intentions and ultimately turnover (Arnold and Feldman 1982); that is, higher levels of job satisfaction lead to reduced levels of both turnover intentions and employee turnover. Thus, it is further hypothesized that:

H2a: Lower levels of role conflict will lead to increased levels of job satisfaction.

H2b: Lower levels of role ambiguity will lead to increased levels of job satisfaction.

H3: Higher levels of job satisfaction will lead to decreased turnover intentions in salespeople.

Salesperson grit

The current work also pulls from the positive-psychology literature by examining the impact of salesperson grit on modeled constructs. The grit construct, referred to as a person's character and overall ability to persevere in the face of trying circumstances (Singh and Jha 2008), has an established research tradition in the positive psychology literature. However, it's efficacy in the sales realm needs to be explored in more detail (e.g. Dugan et al. 2019). The construct has also been defined as dedication in enduring long-term goals (Duckworth et al. 2007). Grit includes working vigorously toward goals while maintaining discipline and interest regardless of past failures and current challenges (Duckworth et al. 2007). Proponents of the grit construct argue that grit helps to explain why two different individuals who have similar ability levels can vary significantly in overall task performance (Crede, Tynan, and Harms 2017). Individuals with high grit levels remain focused on the task and are insulated from failure driven discouragement.

Duckworth's (2006) series of studies also reveals that grit is a better indicator of success than IQ in more difficult settings. Similarly, (Duckworth and Eskreis-Winkler 2013) found that grit is often independent of, or even negatively correlated to, skill in a particular task. These findings also reflect those of Maddi et al. (2012) who found that military cadets who remained in the academy were twice as likely to have high grit scores versus those who did not. Based on these studies, the role of grit can be extended to the sales context given the challenging nature of turbulent environments, intense competition, required goal targets, and the reality of consistent rejection (e.g., Loveland et al. 2015). This logic leads to the idea that salespeople who possess grit will remain dedicated to their work in spite of potentially lower levels of job satisfaction; thus, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4: Salesperson-grit moderates the relationship between job satisfaction and turnover intentions such that salespeople with higher levels of grit exhibit a weaker link between satisfaction and turnover intentions than do salespeople with lower levels of grit.

It is also argued that grit also serves as a moderator between role stressors and job satisfaction in that it attenuates the links between both role conflict and role ambiguity on job satisfaction. The justification being that if a salesperson has higher levels of grit, then the potentially damaging effects of role stressors on job satisfaction should be mitigated. This is similar to what Duckworth and Quinn (2009) found in military academy students: those with higher levels of grit were less likely to quit when faced with stressful situations. Therefore, it is proposed that grit moderates the relationships between role stressors and job satisfaction such that:

H5a: Salespeople with higher levels of grit show a weaker link between role conflict and job satisfaction than do salespeople with lower levels of grit.

H5b: Salespeople with higher levels of grit show a weaker link between role ambiguity and job satisfaction than do salespeople with lower levels of grit.

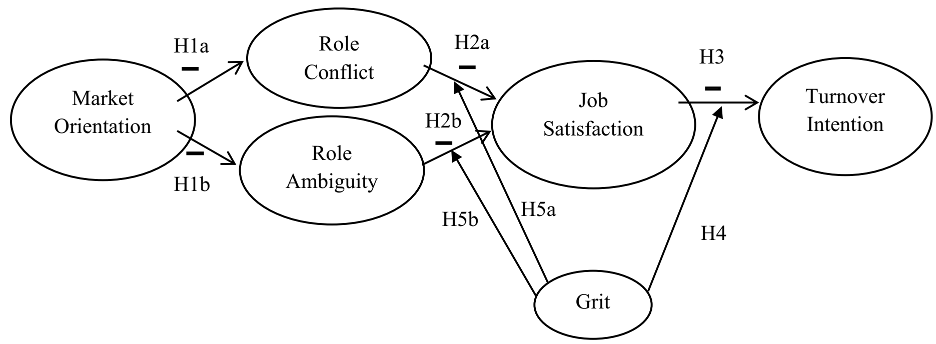

Figure 1. Hypothesized model.

An overview of the hypothesized model is presented in Figure 1.

Study

Sample

A Qualtrics survey panel was selected as the sample for this study with the sample consisting of 260 respondents who were employed full-time and worked in either B2B or B2C sales as boundary-spanning employees. The age range for the sample was 18–25 which, based on the dates of data collection, places them in either late Generation Y (the first half of the millennial generational cohort born between the early-80"s and mid-90"s) or early Generation Z (the second half of the millennial generational cohort born after the mid-90s and raised in the 2000's) collectively termed the millennial generational cohort by Tulgan (2013). The sample was 72.3% female in order to incorporate the changing composition of the salesforce. As of 2017, millennial workers are the largest age-cohort within the US workforce (Fry 2018) and women make up almost 50% of professional US workers (Kochhar 2020). These respondents had been with their current employer for an average of 19.44 months (range 1–96 months).

Measures

The measures utilized in this study have been used in previous research and have demonstrated acceptable reliability and validity. Market orientation was measured on a 14-item scale originally constructed by Narver and Slater (1995)) and adapted by Hooley et al. (2000). The 14 items are broken into three facets: customer orientation (MOC) assessed with four items, competitor orientation (MOE) assessed with six items, and internal dissemination of information (MOI) assessed with four items as originally conceptualized Narver and Slater (1995)). The results of prior studies show that there were no discrepancies in the scale across industry sector or market type (consumer vs. industrial, services vs. manufacturing, or fast moving vs. durables). Role conflict (eight items) and role ambiguity (six items) scales were adapted from Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman (1970). Job satisfaction was evaluated using a five-item scale comprised by (Hartline and Ferrell 1996). Grit, as conceptualized by Duckworth et al. (2007) as a second order construct that has two first-order facets (consistency of interest and perseverance of effort), was measured with two six-item scales: grit – consistency of interests (CI) and grit – perseverance of efforts (PE). Turnover intentions were assessed via a six-item scale created by Bothma and Roodt (2013). Each scale item was measured on a six-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, and 6 = strongly agree).

Analysis

Analysis of the latent constructs was conducted using PLS-SEM via SmartPLS2 (Ringle, Wende, and Will 2005). PLS-SEM was selected as the analytic technique given that it works well with smaller sample sizes and data that is not multivariate normally distributed, and that it is designed to more easily handle non-linear paths (moderating effects). All of these properties were elements of this data and the hypothesized model. The model was assessed as specified in the hypotheses and was estimated using the PLS algorithm to obtain path coefficient estimates. Construct quality was verified using both internal consistency measures along with convergent and discriminant validity checks based on the latent variable correlations of the constructs and the square root of each construct's AVE. Finally, the hypotheses were tested using the bootstrapping procedure in the program using 500 draws of 250 cases.

Scale quality

The first step was to run the proposed model through the base PLS algorithm to examine latent variable quality. As can be seen in Table 1, all of the scales exhibited acceptable internal consistency (Cronbach's alpha scores above 0.70 and composite reliability scores above 0.80). The scales also showed adequate discriminant validity scores with the square root of AVE for each construct being greater than that construct's correlation with the other latent variables. The only suspect aspect of the measurement of the latent variables was the relatively low AVE scores for three of the constructs. Specifically, role conflict, Grit-PE and turnover intentions were below the 0.50 threshold (Fornell and Larcker 1981). These scales all exhibited AVEs over 0.4 and had no other indications of psychometric issues.

PLS-SEM paths

The hypothesized relationships were examined via the PLS-SEM path model. As can be seen in Table 1, the path model supported the hypotheses with two exceptions. The supported hypotheses of a significant negative relationship between (1) market orientation and role ambiguity, (2) the negative relationships between role conflict and ambiguity and job satisfaction and (3) the negative relationship between job satisfaction and turnover intentions all reinforce the conceptualization of market orientation as a job resource. Specifically, market orientation reduces employee perceptions of role ambiguity by giving them a clearly defined role and sharing that through internal company communications, which leads to greater feelings of job satisfaction and reduced turnover as expected in the JD-R framework.

The first exception to the hypothesized relationships was that the path from market orientation to role conflict (H1a) was not significant while it was significant for the role ambiguity stressor (H1b). Market orientation explained 35.4% of the variance in role ambiguity while only explaining 0.4% of the variance in role conflict. These findings lend support to the idea that while market orientation functions as a resource pool or helps to preserve salesperson resources in the job-demands-resources model structure; it only applies to certain types of demands. One possible explanation for this is that salespeople in the same firm could be exposed to similar levels of market orientation information from the firm, but could experience vastly different role conflict levels depending on the individuals with whom they interact. It could also be argued that role ambiguity is an individual level perception of a departmental or organizational level phenomena similar to how organizational safety is conceptualized by Neal and Griffin (2006), putting it at the same level of aggregation as market orientation while role conflict operates at the individual-to-individual level of aggregation. Also, the nature of market orientation in its three facets leans toward a stronger *prima fascia* case for a relationship with role ambiguity than with role conflict.

The second exception was that grit did not moderate the link between role ambiguity and job satisfaction (H5b) but does moderate the role conflict to job satisfaction relationship (H5a). This finding seems reasonable as conflict tends to be at the person-to-person level, and as such, the "grittier" individual would be expected to be able to overcome this type of situation, and to persist, where as a less "gritty" person would be expected to experience a much more diminished satisfaction level with their job given the same level of role conflict. On the other hand, role ambiguity has to do with a lack of direction and clarity which suggests that the grittier individual does not have anything directly to overcome, but rather is dealing with an absence of guidance. However, the finding that grit moderates the relationship between role conflict and job satisfaction does means that grit can serve as an insulating personality factor that reduces the strength of the negative associations between stressors and outcomes in the JDR model as proposed in positive psychology (e.g., Duckworth 2016). Even with the two non-supported hypotheses, the model shows the power of market orientation on salesperson job satisfaction and turnover intentions is relatively large in terms of magnitude as show in Table 1.

Post Hoc testing

In addition, the model was assessed without grit to see what the incremental increase in explanatory power for job satisfaction and turnover intentions was by adding the moderating effects. The results suggest that the moderating impact of grit on the role conflict to job satisfaction link explains an additional 3.1% of the variance in job satisfaction versus the model without the moderating effect. The moderating effect of grit on the job satisfaction to turnover intentions link explains an additional 1.7% of variance in turnover intentions. This indicates that while grit does moderate these relationships, the impact is relatively small. A summary of findings for each hypothesis in each study is shown in Table 2.

Discussion and implications

Practitioner implications

This research suggests that role ambiguity can be reduced by the presence of a market orientation. Market orientation explains a small amount of the variance in role clarity, but accounts for almost 40% of the variance in role ambiguity. This indicates that firms whose employees perceive their employer as having a positive market orientation experience more clearly defined roles as a result of that market orientation. This reduction in role ambiguity leads to an increase in job satisfaction which leads to reduced turnover intention. Thus, this study indicates that there may be a cost-saving

Table 1. PLS-SEM results.

Latent Variable Quality

Construct/Facet	AVE	Composite Reliability	Cronbach's Alpha	R Square
MO-MOC	0.5271	0.8697	0.8200	N/A
MO-MOE	0.5421	0.8242	0.7180	N/A
MO-MOI	0.5109	0.8057	0.6814	N/A
MO (2nd Order)	0.3683	N/A	N/A	N/A
RA	0.5844	0.8933	0.8560	0.3541
RC	0.4322	0.8550	0.8330	0.0037
Grit-CI	0.5637	0.8841	0.8427	N/A
Grit-PE	0.4941	0.8533	0.7941	N/A
Grit (2nd order)	0.3067	N/A	N/A	NA
Job sat	0.6572	0.9053	0.8688	0.3730
TOI	0.4205	0.8062	0.7358	0.4483

Latent Variable Correlations

	Grit	Job sat.	MO	RA	RC	TOI
Grit (2nd order)	0.5546					
Job satisfaction	0.1728	0.8107				
Market Orientation (2nd Order)	0.1703	0.5868	0.6069			
Role Ambiguity	−0.3112	−0.5766	−0.5947	0.7644		
Role Conflict	−0.3449	−0.1991	−0.0520	0.1905	0.6574	
Turn-Over Intentions	−0.2100	−0.6151	−0.2915	0.3117	0.3277	0.6484

Note: Diagonal elements are the square root of the AVE for the construct

Model Paths

Model Path	Coefficient	Standard Error	t-value
MO → RA	−0.5950	0.0410	14.4999
MO → RC	−0.0610	0.1205	*0.5059*
RA → Job sat	−0.3893	0.3677	*1.0586*
RA * Grit → Job sat	−0.1183	0.3337	*0.3545*
RC → Job sat	−0.1420	0.0846	1.6783
RC * Grit → Job sat	−0.1821	0.0820	2.2217
Job sat → TOI	−0.5683	0.0523	10.8594
Job sat * Grit → TOI	−0.2495	0.0502	4.9682

Note: italicized *t*-values are not significant at the = 0.05 level

Total Effects

Path	Effect	Standard Error	t-value
MO → TOI	−0.1733	0.0279	6.2039
MO → Job sat	0.3049	0.0431	7.0746

Note: All *t*-values are significant at the = 0.05 level.

Table 2. Summary of findings.

Hypothesis	Result
H1a: A market orientation leads to decreased role conflict of salespeople	***Not Supported***
H1b: A market orientation leads to decreased role ambiguity of salespeople	Supported
H2a: Decreased role conflict leads to increased job satisfaction of salespeople	Supported
H2b: Decreased role ambiguity leads to increased job satisfaction of salespeople	Supported
H3: Increased job satisfaction leads to decreased turnover intentions of salespeople	Supported
H4: Grit moderates the relationship between job satisfaction and turnover intentions	Supported
H5a: Grit moderates the relationship between role conflict and turnover intentions	Supported
H5b: Grit moderates the relationship between role ambiguity and turnover intentions	***Not Supported***

benefit (e.g., recruiting and retention efforts, lost sales, etc.) that accrues to firms with a market orientation due to reduced salesperson turnover via role perceptions (Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970). This supports that the idea that organizations can benefit from market orientation not only externally, but also internally in terms of mitigating stressors placed on boundary-spanning employees. Therefore, companies should push for adoption of market orientation in order to alleviate some key role stressors placed on their salespeople in addition to the already established benefits from external customers.

The link between grit, job satisfaction, and turnover intentions is another positive finding. As expected, job satisfaction helps reduce turnover intentions; however, the relationship is moderated by grit in such a way that people with higher grit show a weaker link between job satisfaction and turnover intentions while those with lower levels of grit show a stronger link between job satisfaction and turnover intentions. This raises human resource issues in the hiring process: human resource managers should work to identify salespeople with high levels of grit in order to better minimize turnover intentions given the cost of turnover to organizations. As noted by Zoltners, Sinha, and Lorimer (2008) businesses spent upwards of $15 billion training their sales forces and that cost has only risen while Darmon (2008) noted that salesforce turnover is as high as 27%. Sales managers should consider using a grit scale as part of the interview alongside traditional measures to determine the likelihood of success of a new sales hire, openly share that grit is a desired characteristic, and actively recruit salespeople with high levels of the construct. Personality testing is commonplace in hiring decisions today, though not without controversy. Given that personality is a major factor in preferences and behavior, and that it often affects job performance by indicating the natural fit of the employee to the job (Haynie, 2021), its popularity is understandable. Of course, all testing must follow Equal Employment Opportunity requirements. It is also noted that Grit was found to reduce the negative relationship between role conflict and job satisfaction making selection of employees with higher levels of grit even more desirable as it appears that grit doubly effects the paths that lead to turnover intentions. This is in keeping with the findings of Dugan et al. (2019) of a main effect of grit on objective sales performance and job satisfaction. The findings of this study indicate that if a firm is hiring for an industry in which customer contact employees chronically experience lower levels of job sat, then it would behoove them to include a measure of grit in their hiring metrics.

Practitioner recommendations

This research helps to form a clear set of guidelines for practitioners to consider:

(1) Apply a combination of retention strategies from the top down and bottom up – Of course employers want to have a strong market orientation along with its other attendant benefits, and in these cases grit has a reduced effect on salespeople turnover intentions; however, when firms suffer from a weak market orientation then it is advised that greater emphasis be placed on the salesperson's level of grit because this internal trait is less likely to cause a salesperson to entertain leaving because of a lack of market orientation. Having many different employee retention strategies provides multiple ways to meet the psychological needs of salespeople (Hartmann and Rutherford 2015).

(2) Use Grit to practice meaningful behaviors – Studies on grit indicate that the most prominent link between grit and success is calculated practice; those who possess more grit are more willing to deliberately practice their work in order to achieve their goals (Duckworth and Eskreis-Winkler 2013). Hence, whatever the initial grit level of a salesperson is, it is most helpful to use that determination to practice the right behaviors for greater success. Any and all means used to prepare traditional skills (e.g., role plays, presentation skills, dealing with objections, online selling, etc.) and less obvious skills (e.g., empathy, curiosity, critical thinking, etc.) can all be practiced to improve selling, closing, and customer fulfillment outcomes (Thomas 2021). Therefore, detecting a salesperson's grit is only the beginning; it should be focused on organization goals and put to good use.
(3) Understand that something new is happening with middle aged workers – The US Bureau of Labor Statistics reports that turnover is historically highest among younger employees (20 to 25 years range) who are thought to be more unsettled, unsure of their interests, and may not always be properly trained. This may be even more important to new salespeople whose early career frustration and failure is thought to be the impetus for this group's willingness to jump from job to job, and even out of a professional sales careers (Thomas 2021). For all types of workers, this has not been the case during the 2020 and 2021 "Great Resignation." Instead, turnover dropped for younger workers not in the food service industry (Cook 2021). Between 2020 and 2021 the age group most likely to quit appears to be middle aged (30 to 45 years of age) with an average increase of 20% (Cook 2021). This trend is potentially dangerous for business leaders because this age group represents mid-level workers who have proven track records, are costly to replace, and who encompass the pool of workers to provide the next generation of business leaders. Retaining mid-career salespeople who have already overcome early career bumps and bruises is important for sales teams to reach revenue targets on a consistent basis (Thomas 2021).
(4) Pay attention to the forces unique to the industry – Workers with essential knowledge who experience turnover intentions are more likely to leverage their unique skills and experiences with new employers, but in the same industry. Employees in industries that were placed under greater stress due to the demands of the COVID-19 pandemic (i.e., forced to deal with greater workloads and coworker burnout) were more likely to quit. For example, resignation rates were highest in healthcare and high tech industries (Cook 2021). An added danger for sales managers who are responsible for retaining salespeople is the fact that good salespeople have skills related to selling and may be able to more easily transfer to new employers even in different industries. Given the difficulty of tracking potential rivals, a good retention strategy is to be proactive and to focus on the needs and concerns of existing sales and support personnel.
(5) Use analytics to track turnover, look for insights, and customize a solution – For example, Ian Cook (HR consultant, researcher and journalist) and his team searched 9 million employee records at over 4,000 global companies to develop generic steps for business leaders to consider (2021). He recommends employers should use a data-drive approach to: 1) identify root causes why employees quit that are unique to the firm; 2) use metrics to quantify, track, and clarify the cost of turnover so all stakeholders understand what is a risk; and, 3) implement targeted retention campaigns to address the problems unique to each employer and its employees.
(6) Set employee retention goals and action plans as a team – Once an employer understands the larger market forces, industry trends and the specific characters of the organization's employees, retention goals should be developed by the entire workforce. A firm's market orientation should be

a team goal and responsibility. Hence, setting retention goals as a group communicates the importance of retention to everyone, and emphasizes further that a productive and content workforce is the mutual responsibility of all employees throughout the organization. Sunder et al. (2017) used a sample of over 6,700 salespeople and found strong evidence that peer turnover influenced other salespeople's turnover intentions. In addition, multiple retention strategies developed by employees for employees may be the best way to develop action plans that target key concerns and foster ownership by team members. Ultimately, this may be the best way to create a culture where salespeople feel pride in being part of a winning organization.

Research implications

Inclusion of market orientation as an antecedent to role stressors in the job Demands-Resources model expands the conceptualization of the construct as it relates to salespeople in that market orientation is something the firm can control directly. This opens research opportunities to use this model in the sales literature. The current research has helped support the internal marketing consequences of market orientation, supporting and extending the findings of Narver and Slater (1995)); Kohli and Jaworski (1990); Lings and Greenley (2009) to the sales domain. In addition, the job-demands-resources model expands the role of grit beyond positive psychology to be viewed as a resource in stressful situations and puts the role of grit into a theoretical framework for use in business contexts. In addition, the current work suggests that the grit scale can be used to replace measures used for similar constructs such as tenacity (Avila and Fern 1986). Research indicates that a person who is tenacious is more likely to persevere through a task or job (Avila and Fern 1986); and, given their conceptual similarity, similar outcomes can be expected in a person who possesses grit. However, since tenacity has proven to be an unreliable measure, grit is proposed herein as a replacement construct, having been psychometrically validated in multiple studies (Crede, Tynan, and Harms 2017; Duckworth 2006, 2016; Duckworth and Eskreis-Winkler 2013; Duckworth and Quinn 2009; Duckworth et al. 2007).

Limitations and future research

Combining these two literature streams – market orientation and salesperson grit – is novel and will inspire new thinking and foster new insights. This study serves as a starting point for future research to examine firm controllable resources (market orientation) along with employee traits that can act as a buffer (grit) when resources are scarce. A limitation of the research is that it only contains responses from the United States, and failure to retain key sales employees is a problem with global implications. To date, there is relatively little research on salesperson turnover as an international phenomena (see Appendix 2), so research employing the JD-R framework to examine salesperson turnover from a global perspective is warranted.

Additionally, the link between turnover intentions and actual turnover behavior should be assessed in a longitudinal manner to determine whether grit moderates this link. Another set of studies should assess other internal consequences of market orientation on salespeople including motivation, performance, organization citizenship behaviors and lone-wolf tendencies. Furthermore, research that combines the grit construct with team performance can prove valuable to organizations who increasingly pair sales representatives together to increase territory performance (Cummings 2007). Finally, the question needs to be answered as to whether grit is distinct and shows discriminant validity from similar constructs such as tenacity, persistence, and/or mental toughness. Additionally, grit can be tested in multiple ways – to determine the level of grit inherent in salespeople, to see if grit can be increased through training and development, and if grit can be situation-dependent.

In summary, this study's findings suggest that role ambiguity can be reduced by the presence of a positive market orientation culture that increases job satisfaction, which leads to reduced turnover intention. Findings also suggest that salesperson grit moderates the relationship between role conflict and job satisfaction, but does not moderate the relationship between role ambiguity and job satisfaction. Hence, a market-orientation culture has internal organizational benefits for salespeople, and salesperson grit can serve as an insulating personality factor when role conflict is prevalent.

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Appendix 1: Overview of empirical on salespeople turnover research

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(Johnston et al. 1987)	Insurance sales agents Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Job tenure Age Education Assessment of supervisor Intrinsic job satisfaction Extrinsic job satisfaction
(Johnston et al. 1987)	New salespeople of national manf. Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Org commitment Pay satisfaction Promotion satisfaction Supervisor satisfaction Co-worker satisfaction
(Johnston et al. 1988)	Salespeople of natl manuf. retail products Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Propensity to leave Performance Job satisfaction (pay, promotion, coworkers, work, supervisor)
(Sager, Varadarajan, and Futrell 1988)	Salespeople of natl manf. retail products Silent & Boomers Gender: 5% female	Mobley (1977) General Model of Employee Turnover (positive thoughts about quitting → lead to research for alternatives → found favorable alternative → 5leads to i6ntention to quit)	Satisfaction (pay, promotion, supervisor, work, coworker). Thinking of quitting Attitude toward searching Attitude toward quitting Comparison of perceived alt job w/present job Intention to leave
(Sager, Futrell, and Varadarajan 1989)	Salespeople Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Intention to quit Performance Tenure Org commitment Alternative job offer Job Satisfaction (pay, promotion, supervisor, work, coworkers).
(Fern, Avila, and Grewal 1989)	Salespeople w/in large computer manufacture Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Demographic & Individual Characteristics (age, marital status, no. of independents, educ., life cycle state, hours worked per week, experience, ave. sales, yr in territory, job security) Work related factors (job satisfaction, role conflict, role ambiguity, org commitment) Performance (work w/others), technical knowledge, sales produced, customer relations, info collected, present skill, time mgmt, overall perform, and percent of quota).
(Johnston and Futrell 1989)	Salespeople of natl manf. retail products Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Turnover frequency Turnover functionality Propensity of leave Leadership role clarification Leadership consideration Role conflict Role ambiguity Overall job satisfaction Salary
(Moncrief, Hoverstad, and Lucas 1989)	Insurance sales agents Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Survival Analysis, a biomedical-life-sciences technique to examine the pattern of attrition of a selected sample over time (e.g., survival rate of cancer patients)	"Hazard rate" the point whereby a type of salesperson is most likely to self-terminate. As in, the hazard rate for ins sales agents is 15 months. "Survival rate" 41% of insurance sales agents remain employed after 24 months.
(Ingram and Lee 1990)	Salespeople across 37 industrial firms Silent & Boomers Gender not reported	Not reported	Job withdrawal propensity (new job in same org) Org withdrawal propensity (leave the org) Org commitment Job commitment
. (Ingram and Lee 1990)	Salespeople & mgrs. of computer equipment manf. Silent & Boomers Gender: 11% female	None reported	Role stress (role conflict, role ambiguity, role overload)

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Appendix 1: (Continued).

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(George and Bettenhausen 1990)	Salespeople & mgrs from 33 retail stores in national chain Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender not reported	Prosocial Behavior in Groups	Group cohesiveness Leadership positive mood Group sales performance
(Sager 1991)	Salespeople at a natl. manf. of consumer products Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 4% female	None reported	Job stress Fairness Global satisfaction Thoughts of quitting Intent of leave Comparison of perceived alternative Stay vs Quit
(Wotruba and Tyagi 1991)	Salespeople from direct selling firms (Mary Kay, Saladmaster, Tupperware, & United Consumer Club) Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 90% female	Not reported	Met expectations – the diff btwn what the salesperson expects on the job and that which one experiences.
(McNeilly and Russ 1992)	Salespeople in food brokerage who call on supermarket retailers Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender not reported	Not reported	Role conflict Role ambiguity Organizational commitment Job satisfaction Intent to leave Performance
(Tyagi and Wotruba 1993)	Salespeople from direct selling firms (Mary Kay, Saladmaster, Tupperware, & United Consumer Club) Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 85% female	Not reported	Leader goal emphasis & work facilitation Leader trust & support Leader interaction facilitation Organizational identification Management concern and awareness Job satisfaction Organizational commitment Quitting intentions
(Sager 1994)	Salespeople at a natl. manf. of consumer products Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 10% female	Not reported	Sales managers consideration Role conflict Role ambiguity Job stress Overall job satisfaction Organizational commitment Intention to leave
(Sager 1994)	Salespeople at a natl. manf. of consumer products Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender not reported	Not reported	Overall job satisfaction Thinking of quitting Comparison of a perceived alternative job Intention to search Intention to leave
(Jones et al. 1996)	National field sales force of manf. goods Slient, Boomers & GenX Gender: 2% female	Not reported	Leadership consideration Leadership role clarity Role conflict Role ambiguity Job anxiety Job satisfaction Job tension Propensity of leave
(Roberts, Coulson, and Chonko 1999)	Outside salespeople across 80 industries Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 15% female	Equity Theory	Intent to turnover Organizational commitment Internal procedural justice Internal distributive justice Internal Equity (with my org: raise equity, fringe benefit equity, promotion equity, incentive equity, salary equity, & recognition equity). External Equity (at other firms in my industry: with my org: raise equity, fringe benefit equity, promotion equity, incentive equity, salary equity, & recognition equity).
(Pettijohn, Pettijohn, and Taylor 1999)	Retail salespeople from across 54 stores Silent, Boomers & Gen X Gender: 65% female	Not reported	Performance appraisals

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Appendix 1: (Continued).

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(Naumann, Widmier, and Jackson 2000)	Salespeople based in Asia Boomers & GenX Gender not reported	Not reported	Propensity to leave Salesperson Attitudes: job satisfaction, org commitment, & job involvement Individual Characteristics: age, fluency in host language, years of intl experience, tenure, education, & met expectations. Job characteristics: role conflict, role ambiguity, skill variety, task identity, task significance & autonomy Origination Characteristics: participation, expatriate training, org size, & org age
(McElroy, Morrow, and Rude 2001)	Salespeople in financial services (e.g., mortgages) Boomers & GenX Gender not reported	Not reported	Voluntary turnover (employee decides to quick/ retire). Involuntary turnover (dismissal for lack of performance or undesirable behavior) Reduction-in-force turnover (layoffs)
(Schwepker 2001)	Various B2B Salespeople Boomers & GenX Gender: 29% female	Not reported	Ethical climate Job Satisfaction (pay, promotions, supervisor, policy, customers, workers, job) Organizational commitment Turnover intent
(Flaherty and Pappas 2002a)	Auto salespeople Boomers & GenX Gender: 13% female	Career Stage Theory	Life stage (exploration, establishment, maintenance, & disengagement) Turnover intention Job satisfaction Org commitment Education Age Job tenure Occupation tenure
(Flaherty and Pappas 2002b)	Salespeople in service industry from cross-section of US industries. Boomers & GenX Gender: 33% female	Career stage theory Contingency theory	Job satisfaction Turnover intentions Career stage (exploration, establishment, maintenance, & disengagement) SBU strategy (Defender, Prospector, or Analyzer) Compensation type (salary or incentive). Age Marital status Firm size
(Brashear et al. 2003)	B2B Salespeople based in US across industries Silent, Boomers & GenX Gender: 22% female	Theoretical Model of Interpersonal Trust	Managerial opportunism Managerial respect Shared values (mgr/slprsn) Salesperson trust Benevolence Honesty Job satisfaction "Relationalsim" Organizational commitment Turnover intention
(Brashear, Manolis, and Brooks 2005)	B2B salespeople US based across various industries Boomers & Gen X Gender: 33% female	Equity Theory	Process control Decision control Trust Procedural justice Distributive justice Turnover intentions
(Brashear et al. 2003)	Retail salespeople across 16 states Boomers, GenX & Mill Gender: 5% female	Role Theory Job Stress Theory	Ethical climate Role ambiguity Role conflict Organizational commitment Job satisfaction Turnover intention Job performance Gender Age Tenure Total work experience

(*Continued*)

Appendix 1: (Continued).

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(Jones et al. 2007)	US based sales & marketing executives Boomers, GenX & Mill Gender not reported	Career stage theory	Performance Turnover intent Role overload Job satisfaction Organizational commitment
(Pettijohn, Pettijohn, and Taylor 2008)	US based retail salespeople Boomer, GenX & Mill Gender: 47% female	Theory of cognitive dissonance	Ethical attitude toward business in general Ethical attitude toward employer Attitude as consumer Job satisfaction Turnover intentions
(Pettijohn et al. 2007)	Retail sales from 9 stores in US Boomer, GenX & Mill Gender: 35% female	Not reported	Sales skills (techniques: prospecting, need ident, present, objections, close, etc.) Sales behaviors (consulting clients) Customer orientation Organization commitment Job satisfaction Intent to leave Performance
(Lewin and Sager 2009)	B2B Salespeople w/in manf. products industry Boomers, GenX & Mill Gender: 27% female	Cognitive Appraisal Theory	Emotional exhaustion Role conflict Role ambiguity Problem coping strategy Emotion coping strategy
(Proudfoot et al. 2008)	Salespeople of insurance services industry Boomer, GenX & Mill Gender: 2% female	Cognitive Behavioral Theory	Attributional style (positive or negative attribution) Psychological distress Job satisfaction Self-esteem Intention to quit
(Brashear et al. 2003)	US based sales managers and salespeople Boomer, Gen X & Mill Gender: 22% female	Not reported	Procedural justice Interpersonal justice Informational justice Distributive justice Perceived organization support Perceived supervisor support Organizational commitment Turnover intentions
(Jaramillo et al. 2009)009)	Salespeople across various US based industries Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 53% female	Virtue ethics theory	Servant Leadership (relationship with subordinates, empowering subordinates, helping subordinates grow, behaving ethically, having conceptual skills, putting subordinates first, creates value outside the organization) Ethical level Person-organizational fit Organizational commitment Sales experience Felt stress Turnover intention
(Brashear et al. 2003)	N = 495 US based salesforce of chemical products Age not reported Gender: 27% female (note: 40% of new hires are female)	Social learning theory	Organizational Stressors: role clarity & role conflict Personal Characteristic: self-efficacy & external locus of control Coping Styles: emotion focused & problem focused Job-related strains: emotional exhaustion and job anxiety Job-related outcomes: job satisfaction & withdrawal
(Brashear et al. 2003)	N = 141 US based retail salespeople Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: not specified except majority were male	Not reported	Organizational commitment Job Satisfaction Intent-to-leave Customer orientation Introductory training Sales skills Customer satisfaction Product knowledge Company/Industry knowledge

(*Continued*)

Appendix 1: (Continued).

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(Lewin and Sager 2010)	N = 495 US based salesforce of chemical products Age not reported Gender: 27% female (note: 40% of new hires are female)	Self-efficacy theory	Self-efficacy External locus of control Problem-focused coping Emotion-focused coping Turnover intention
(Lewin and Sager 2010)	N = 130 French B2C salespeople Age not reported Gender: 25% female		Person-Career fit Ethical climate Satisfaction Role overload Self-efficacy Propensity to leave Performance
(Brashear et al. 2003)	N = 393 salespeople Boomers, GenX, Mill Gender: 27% female	Organizational Identification Theory	Responsibility/trust Ethical norms Peer behavior Sales practices Supervisory trust Organizational identification Organizational commitment Turnover intentions Turnover
(DeConinck 2011)	N = 356 US based B2B salespeople Age not provided Gender: 36% female	Social Exchange Theory & Leader-member exchange Theory	Leader-member exchange Organizational identification Performance Organizational commitment Turnover intentions Turnover
(DeConinck 2011)	N = 127 US based retail salespeople (and N = 781 healthcare workers) Age not reported Gender: 51% female	Not reported	Work Context: group creativity and corporate ethical values Work Response: job satisfaction and turnover intention Social desirability
(Rutherford, Park, and Han 2011)	N = 213 department store salespeople (S. Korea) Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 80% female	Not reported	Emotional exhaustion Perceived Org Support Job satisfaction Org commitment Job performance Propensity to leave
(Dimaculangan and Aguiling 2012)	N = 387 salespeople in Philippines Ages not provided Gender: 46% female	Not reported	Transformational leadership Ethical climate Person-Org fit Org commitment Turnover intent
(Wang and Ma 2013)	N = 210 US based B2B internal sale people Boomer & Genx Gender: 36% female	Resource Advantage Theory	Climate for innovation Learning orientation Job satisfaction Turnover intention Use of sales teams Sales experience Firm size
(DeConinck 2011)	N = 604 US based salespeople Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 37% female	None reported	Job satisfaction (pay, supervision, job richness, autonomy, org commitment, job involvement) Role stress (role conflict, role ambiguity, propensity to leave) Personal variables (age, gender, family status, spousal employment, income level, education, job tenure, & prior sales experience) Compensation plan (salary, commission, or combination)
(Bande et al. 2015)	N = 209 industrial salespeople from 105 Spanish firms Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 27% female	Theory of Human Capital	Resilience Emotional intelligence (EI) Emotional exhaustion (EE) Work-family conflict (WFC) Servant leadership Turnover intention

(*Continued*)

Appendix 1: (Continued).

Citation sorted by date	Sample Generation Gender	Central Theory	Variables related to Turnover
(Hartmann and Rutherford 2015)	N = 308 salespeople for survey panel in US Boomers & GenX Gender: 43% female	Not reported	Psychological Climate Dimensions: autonomy, involvement, performance feedback, & clarity of org goals. Psychological contract breach Job satisfaction Org commitment Turnover intention Job performance Org tenure Age Gender
(DeConinck 2011)	N = 160 B2B salespeople in UK based firms industrial products Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 19% female	Not reported	Formalization Centralization Activity information Activity rewards Capability information Capability rewards Capability punishment Role ambiguity Role conflict Satisfaction with job Satisfaction with coworkers Satisfaction with supervision Satisfaction with customer Propensity to leave Psychic distance Export sale mgr experience
(Seriki et al. 2016)	N = 348 salespeople at banks in US Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender not reported	Attitude Theory	Marketing messages: incongruent value & inaccurate claim Organizational claim Outcome: Org commitment, job satisfaction & extra-role performance Control variables: individual cynicism & social cynicism
(Skiba, Saini, and Friend 2016)	N = 179 B2B sales managers across many industries Boomers, GenX, Mill Gender: 45% female	Jobs demands-resource theory	Salesforce turnover Cost prioritization Output control Behavior control Micromanagement Firm age Firm size
(Kuvaas et al. 2016)	N = 322 Norwegian insurance salespeople Boomer, GenX, Mill Gender: 41% female	Expectancy theory Reinforcement theory	Base pay Pay for performance (annual & quarterly) Autonomous motivation Controlled motivation Work effort Turnover intention
(Sunder et al. 2017)	N = 6,727 telecomm retail salespeople in US Age not reported Gender not reported	Identity theory Social identity theory	Tenure Goal achievement Customer satisfaction Voluntary per turnover Involuntary per turnover Relative performance Peer performance Peer performance variance Store size
(Shi et al. 2017)	NA – Studied customers who lost their rep	Not reported	NA
(DeConinck, Moss, and Deconinck 2018)	N = 382 US-based B2B industrial manuf & services salespeople Boomers, GenX, Mill Gender: 26% female	Theory of servant leadership	Servant leadership Perceived Org Support Turnover intentions Performance Turnover

Appendix 2: International Research Efforts - Salesperson Turnover

Citation date	Country	Sample
(Lloyd and Newell 2001)	Ireland United Kingdom	Pharma Salespeople
(Guthrie 2001)	New Zealand	Generalized across industries and professional including sales.
(Msweli-Mbanga 2004)	South Africa	Independent sales reps
(Yanadori and Kato 2007)	Japan	Firm level turnover
(Guchait and Cho 2010)	India	Salespeople, customer service, and management
(Smith, Oczkowski, and Smith 2011)	Australia	Professionals (including sales), and tradespeople.
(Msweli-Mbanga 2004)	South Korea	Retail store salespeople
(Yanadori and Kato 2007)	China, Jordan, Turkey USA	Knowledge workers enrolled in EMBA programs
(Hakim Ahmad Dardar, Jusoh, and Rasli 2012)	Libya	Oil industry professionals
(Yanadori and Kato 2007)	Taiwan	Automotive sales/services reps, and supervisors
(Guchait and Cho 2010)	Denmark	Financial sales and services
(Yanadori and Kato 2007)	Malaysia	Automotive sales/services
(Katsikea, Theodosiou, and Morgam 2015)	United Kingdom	Export sales managers
(Kampkotter and Marggraf 2015)	Germany	Multi-national firms
(Peretz, Levi, and Fried 2015)	22 Countries	Firm level data on turnover
(Mathieu et al. 2016)	Canada	Cross sample of various professions including sales
(Park et al. 2016)	China	Bank sales personnel who were protégés in mentoring program
(Kuvaas et al. 2016)	Norway	Insurance sales professionals
(Guchait and Cho 2010)	India	Salespeople across multiple industries